



A PLAYBOOK FOR MEMBERSHIP TEAMS

Member acquisition playbook

Practical strategies to grow membership
through conversational engagement.

CONTENTS

What's inside

01	Executive summary	3
	Why your growth problem isn't what you think	

02	The state of member acquisition today	6
	Four challenges and the leaky funnel	

03	The modern acquisition framework	9
	Ask. Capture. Act.	

04	Five proven acquisition strategies	15
	Website, nurture, events, referrals, students	

05	Metrics that matter	31
	Four numbers and a mini ROI calculator	

06	30-day quick start plan	36
	Four weekly sprints	

07	Conclusion and next steps	42
	Where to go from here	

01

Executive summary

Why your growth problem isn't what you think

Your membership growth problem isn't what you think.

Picture this.

Your team is buried in spreadsheets, endless emails, and competing priorities.

Every day, you're running campaigns to bring in new members. You send out a big "Join Now" campaign. You post on LinkedIn. You run a discount promotion to sweeten the deal.

But all you hear is...crickets.

The executive team asks, "What's going on? Why aren't we growing like we used to?"

Here's the hard truth: **It's not that people don't see your emails. It's that your association isn't part of their conversation.**

THE OLD PLAYBOOK IS BROKEN

Ten years ago, you could blast an email to every prospect and get sign-ups. Now? That same email is buried under 87 other notifications competing for their attention.

Your prospects are overwhelmed. They expect personal, relevant communication.

Not another generic "JOIN NOW!" message that feels like it was written for everyone...and no one. When you treat member acquisition like a one-way announcement, you don't just lose their attention.

You lose their trust.

And without trust, they won't join.

THE NUMBERS DON'T LIE

54%

of associations saw flat or declining membership last year

2025 MGI Membership Marketing Benchmarking Report

65%

of prospective members never even open recruitment emails

PropFuel 2024 Association Email Engagement Benchmark Report

This isn't just a membership or marketing problem. It's a growth problem. A sustainability problem. A "where will we be five years from now" problem.

THE GOOD NEWS

You don't need a bigger budget. Or more emails. Or a last-minute miracle. You really just need a new way to talk to your prospects.

We call it the **Ask. Capture. Act. framework**:

- 01** Ask prospects what they care about (instead of guessing).
- 02** Capture their responses so you actually know them.
- 03** Act with timely, relevant follow-ups that make them feel heard and make your association feel relevant.

When you start having conversations instead of sending campaigns that talk at prospects, everything changes.

What you'll find in this playbook

Over the next few pages, you'll discover:

5 proven strategies

to attract and convert more members.

A 30-day action plan

to see results fast.

The key metrics

to measure what matters most when it comes to member acquisition.

This playbook will help you stop guessing what prospects want and start having the conversations that turn them into members.

02

The state of member acquisition today

Four challenges and the leaky funnel

Why what used to work... doesn't really anymore

THE SHIFT IN MEMBER ACQUISITION

Trends in membership acquisition have changed dramatically over the last few years.

There was a time when a single well-timed recruitment email or a postcard campaign could generate an influx of new members. Today, there's a greater chance those tactics barely make a dent. This isn't because your team is doing anything wrong, it's just that the environment has shifted.

Prospective members are bombarded with competing messages, hundreds of times a day, making it harder than ever to capture their attention, much less earn their trust.

Challenges membership professionals face

01 Greater competition for attention

Your prospective members are overwhelmed with information. It's no surprise that generic recruitment campaigns get ignored.

120

average number of emails received per person, per day

Harvard Business Review (2019). How to Spend Way Less Time on Email Every Day

They are juggling multiple professional networks, social feeds, and marketing messages...not to mention life in general.



02 Siloed teams and technology

Marketing, membership, events, and IT teams often work in isolation, leading to wasted effort and a fractured member experience.

- Data lives in disconnected systems.
- Prospects receive repetitive or irrelevant messaging.

03 One-way communication

Most associations still rely on broadcast messaging: emails, ads, mailers.

- These are one-way pushes of information rather than two-way conversations.
- Prospects are treated like a transaction, not a person.

04 Lack of visibility into what works

Without clear analytics, it's nearly impossible to:

- Know which campaigns are driving results.
- Identify where prospects drop off in the journey.
- Make data-driven decisions about acquisition strategy.

THE COST OF INACTION

When acquisition stalls, the impact ripples across the entire organization.

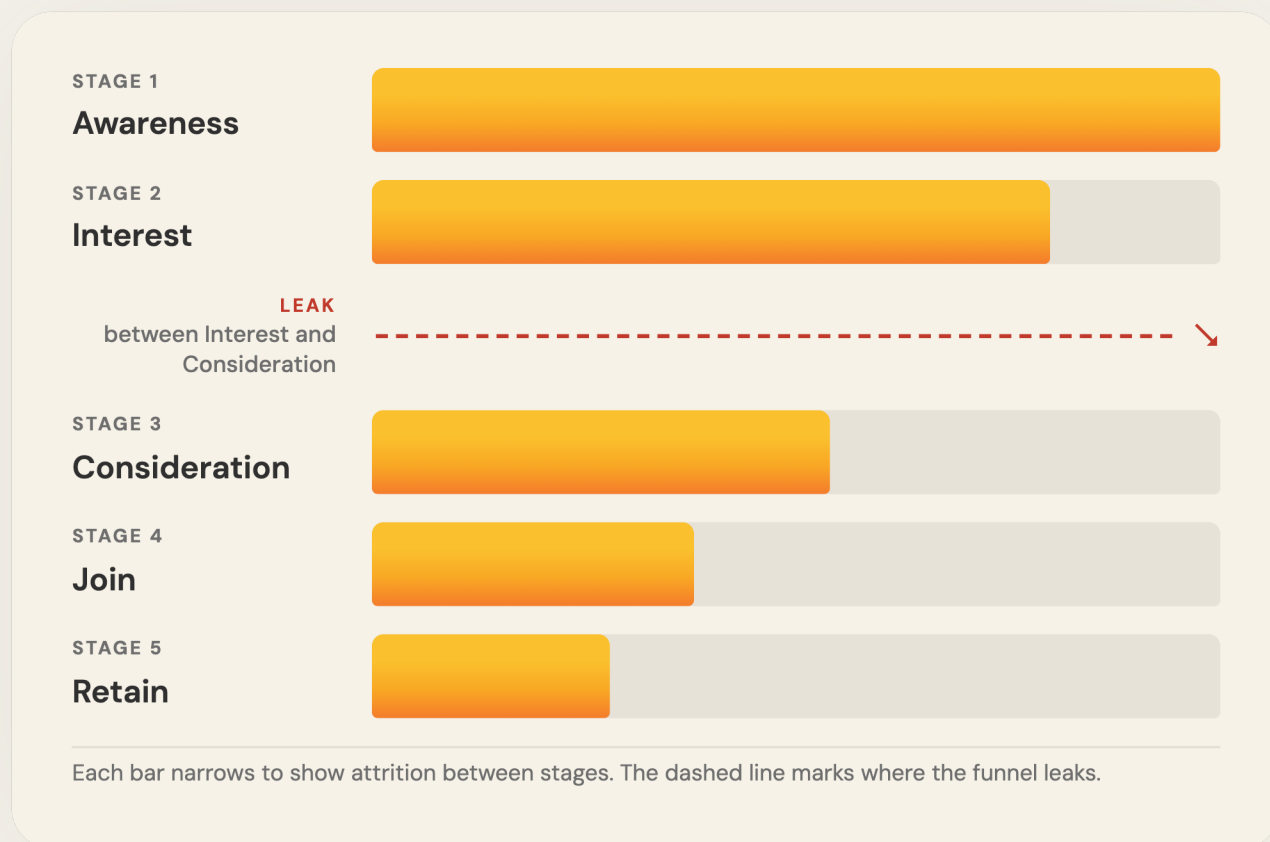
Lost Revenue: Every prospective member who doesn't join represents both immediate and lifetime value gone.

Stalled Impact: Without new members, your association's ability to grow, advocate, and serve its mission diminishes.

Tighter Budgets: Declining membership → lower dues revenue → fewer resources for marketing and recruitment → even flatter growth.

The leaky funnel

Most associations view acquisition as a straightforward, linear path:



But in reality, this funnel leaks. And sometimes, it leaks badly, especially between Interest and Consideration. That's where most prospective members quietly disappear because the experience starts to feel transactional, not relational.

Prospects are often pushed to "Join Now!" before they truly understand the value of membership. Without space for genuine conversation, they never get to share what they need, and the association misses the chance to connect those needs to its offerings.

When there's no dialogue, there's no trust, and without trust, there's no conversion.

Think of it like a leaky bucket: every time you focus on quick transactions instead of meaningful relationships, prospects slip through the cracks. Plugging those leaks starts with shifting from one-way promotion to two-way conversations that make prospects feel seen, heard, and valued.

The rest of this playbook will show you how to create that modern acquisition experience using the Ask. Capture. Act. framework, along with five proven strategies to grow your membership.

03

The modern acquisition framework

Ask. Capture. Act.

How to turn prospects into members

WHY YOU NEED A FRAMEWORK

Right now, most associations are running acquisition campaigns like a game of darts:

- Throw out emails.
- Launch a Facebook ad.
- Post on LinkedIn.

...and they're hoping something sticks. Sometimes it works, but oftentimes, you're actually left with a lot of effort and very little clarity about what actually moved the needle. The fix isn't "more darts"...it's a better system (think: Ask – Capture – Act).

The three-step model for modern acquisition

STEP 1

Ask: stop guessing, start listening

Most associations guess what prospects care about. They make assumptions based on demographics or past behavior, then create campaigns around those assumptions.

But we often forget that people are nuanced.

Instead of guessing, ask them directly:

- What brought them to your website.
- What career goal they're trying to achieve.
- What challenges are keeping them up at night.

EXAMPLE

A visitor lands on your website.

A small, friendly pop-up appears: "Welcome! What brings you here today?"

They click one of five options:

Becoming a member

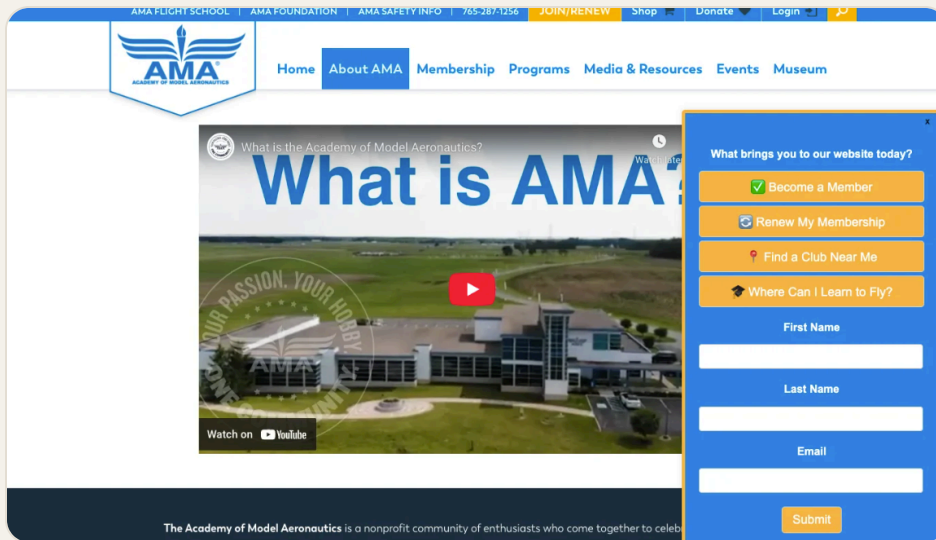
Advancing my career

Finding industry resources

Volunteer opportunities

Registering for the conference

With one click, you've uncovered exactly what matters to them, no assumptions required.



The screenshot shows the AMA (Academy of Model Aeronautics) website. The main content area features a video player titled "What is AMA?" with a play button. The sidebar on the right contains a form titled "What brings you to our website today?". The form has four radio button options: "Become a Member" (checked), "Renew My Membership", "Find a Club Near Me", and "Where Can I Learn to Fly?". Below these options are three text input fields labeled "First Name", "Last Name", and "Email". A "Submit" button is at the bottom of the form.

A visitor to the Academy of Model Aeronautics site is asked one question, with four answer options and three fields.

STEP 2

Capture: turn insights into actionable data

Asking questions is powerful, but only if you store and use the answers. Every time a prospect shares information, capture:

- Their responses to your questions.
- Which content they engage with.
- Where they are in their journey (student, early-career, mid-career, etc.).

This data builds a member profile that lets you segment and personalize outreach.

EXAMPLE

Someone selects "Becoming a Member."

That answer is automatically saved in your system, tagging them as a hot lead.

Now you know not just who they are, but that they're interested in joining.

STEP 3

Act: deliver the right message at the right time

Once you've asked and captured, it's time to act. This means following up with relevant, timely messaging that shows you've been listening.

EXAMPLE

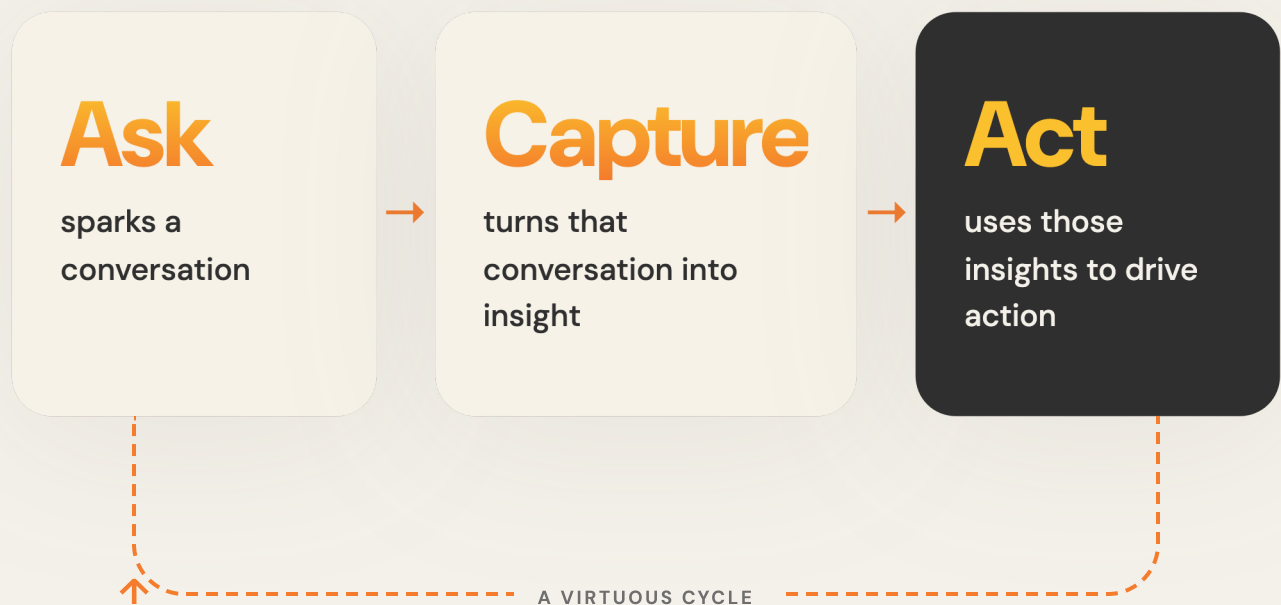
Once someone selects "Becoming a Member," you can automatically direct them to the member benefits page with another question and send a follow-up email with more information on joining.

The left screenshot shows the 'Membership Enrollment' page on the AMA website. It includes a navigation bar with links like 'Home', 'About AMA', 'Membership', 'Programs', 'Media & Resources', 'Events', and 'Museum'. The main heading is 'Membership Enrollment' with the tagline 'JOIN THE LARGEST MODEL AVIATION ORGANIZATION IN THE WORLD!'. Below this, there's a brief description of membership benefits and a section titled 'Please provide us with your information.' which contains a form with fields for Plan (New Adult Membership \$85 or New Senior Membership \$75), Date of Birth, Email Address, Password, Password Confirmation, and Phone Number. The right screenshot shows a 'Ready to Fly?' follow-up card. It features the AMA logo and a background image of model airplanes. The text reads: 'With an AMA Membership from the Academy of Model Aeronautics, you can make that dream a reality. As a member, you'll have access to the resources, support, and community you need to fly safely and confidently.' Below this, it asks 'Are you ready to join the Academy of Model Aeronautics today?' and provides three buttons: 'Yes', 'Maybe - I need more time', and 'No, thanks'.

The enrollment page the answer routes to, and the follow-up card that continues the conversation.

How the pieces work together

Think of it like this:



Each step strengthens the next, creating a virtuous cycle:

- More questions lead to better data.
- Better data lead to more relevant actions.
- Relevant actions lead to higher conversions.

THE ROLE OF TECHNOLOGY

While you can implement Ask. Capture. Act. manually, the right technology makes it seamless.

This is where PropFuel comes in:

Ask prospects a single question via email or a pop-up on your website

Capture their response in PropFuel and write it back to your AMS

Act on their response by sending them information relevant to their interests.

Modern acquisition is about making prospects feel understood.

When someone clicks "join," it's rarely because of a single campaign or email. It's because, at some point, they felt: "This association gets me, and this association can help me."

Ask. Capture. Act. is how you get there, and how you build a growth engine that works in today's noisy, distracted day-to-day.

Next, we'll break down five proven strategies that bring this framework to life, starting with how to optimize your website for conversion.

04

Five proven acquisition strategies

Website, nurture, events, referrals, students

STRATEGY ONE

Optimize your website for conversion

Turn visitors into members before they disappear

THE PROBLEM

Most association websites are designed for current members.

- Content is focused on benefits for people who have already joined.
- Navigation assumes visitors know exactly what they're looking for.
- The "Join Now" button is buried under layers of pages.

The result? Prospective members land on your site, poke around for a few minutes, and then leave, taking their future membership dollars with them.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

50ms

time it takes visitors to form an opinion
about your website

Behaviour & Information Technology Journal

THE SOLUTION

Treat your website like a conversion machine, not just an information hub. With tools like PropFuel's Website Engagement Module, these questions can be seamlessly integrated to capture visitor intent and guide them into a nurture journey. Here's how:

STEP 1

Welcome visitors with a question

Instead of assuming what they want, ask them directly. Use a small, conversational pop-up on key pages:

"What brought you here today?"

Advancing my career

Networking with peers

Learning about certifications

Becoming a member

Registering for the annual conference

This immediately tells you why they're there, so you can guide them to relevant content.

STEP 2

Create clear next steps

Once you know what someone wants, don't make them dig for it.

- Simplify your navigation.
- Use plain, direct language for calls-to-action.

Think of each visitor like they're on a guided tour: First step: orientation. Second step: explore what matters to them. Final step: clear invitation to join.

STEP 3

Personalize the experience

Show prospects content that matches their interests.

- Career-focused visitors see professional development resources.
- Networking-focused visitors see upcoming events.
- Certification seekers see exam prep content.

With PropFuel, these responses can also trigger automated email and SMS campaigns, continuing the conversation beyond the website.

QUICK CHECKLIST

Use this list to start improving your website today:

- ☐ Add a conversational pop-up or question to your homepage.
- ☐ Audit your navigation to remove jargon and simplify language.
- ☐ Review your "Join" page to ensure it as clear and frictionless as possible.
- ☐ Map the top three visitor intents and create tailored content paths for each.
- ☐ Set up a follow-up plan (email or SMS) to nurture visitors who don't join immediately.

STRATEGY TWO

Build a prospect nurture journey

Because most prospects aren't ready to join... yet

THE PROBLEM

Most associations treat prospective members like they're ready to join right now. Here's the usual playbook:

- Someone downloads a resource or attends an event.
- They're added to a list.
- A single "Join Now" email goes out.
- If they don't convert? Silence.

The reality: Only a small percentage of prospects are ready to join the moment they first engage with your organization. The rest need time and a journey that is relevant. One that builds trust, demonstrates value, and guides them to that final "Join" decision.

Without that journey, you're leaving membership growth to chance.

THE SOLUTION

A nurture journey is a series of touchpoints designed to meet prospects where they are and move them toward membership step by step. Think of it like dating. You wouldn't propose on the first date. You'd get to know each other, build trust, and show you care. Membership is no different.

Here's how to build it:

STEP 1

Start with a warm welcome

When someone first interacts with your organization, respond immediately.

- Thank them for showing interest.
- Offer a simple "get to know you" question.
- Let them set the tone for future communications.

"We'd love to get to know you! What's your biggest professional goal right now?"

Advancing my career

Growing my network

Finding resources for my team

STEP 2

Share value, not just benefits

Early in the journey, focus on giving, not asking. Share free resources like blog posts, webinars, or templates. Showcase success stories of members achieving their goals. Make every touchpoint relevant to what they told you in Step 1.

STEP 3

Build to the join invitation

Once you've demonstrated value, make the invitation to join feel natural — like the next logical step.

AVOID

"Join now and save 20%!"

USE INSTEAD

"You've been exploring career resources. Did you know that becoming a member gives you unlimited access to everything you've seen so far?"

STEP 4

Keep the conversation going

If they don't join right away, don't disappear. Follow up periodically with new resources or offers. Use multiple channels: email, SMS, even personalized website messages. Show that you're paying attention to their journey and not just their wallet.

QUICK CHECKLIST

Use this checklist to start building your nurture journey today:

- ☐ Map your audience's top 3 goals or challenges.
- ☐ Draft at least 4 nurture messages: welcome, value, story, invitation.
- ☐ Automate delivery based on timing or prospect behavior.
- ☐ Use multiple channels, such as email, SMS, website messaging.
- ☐ Track conversions and refine the journey over time.



STRATEGY THREE

Leverage events for acquisition

Don't let warm leads go cold after the event

THE PROBLEM

It's likely your association invests heavily in events — conferences, webinars, chapter meetings, etc. At these events, it's also likely you generate hundreds of warm leads, but there's a good chance most of these leads disappear after the event.

Why? Because post-event communication usually includes a generic "thanks for attending, here are the slides!" email, followed by a single generic "join now" email, and then silence.

This "one-and-done" approach misses the entire opportunity to convert attendees into members while their interest is at its peak.

THE SOLUTION

Treat every event like the top of your acquisition funnel, not a stand-alone activity. Along with hosting a great event, the goal is to turn attendees into members through real-time engagement and personalized follow-up.

Here's how to do it step-by-step:

STEP 1

Capture intent before the event

Don't wait until the event is over to start learning about attendees. During registration, ask one question about their goals:

"What's your #1 reason for attending?"

Career growth

Networking

Certification prep/maintenance

This not only gives you valuable insight but also primes attendees for personalized communication later.

STEP 2

Engage during the event

Use real-time channels like SMS or mobile-friendly questions to keep the conversation alive while excitement is high.

EXAMPLES

Day 1 of a conference: "Welcome to the Annual Meeting! What session are you most excited about today?"

Mid-event check-in: "What's been your biggest takeaway so far?"

These questions make attendees feel heard while capturing fresh data about their interests.

STEP 3

Personalized follow-up

Here's where most associations drop the ball: the 48 hours after the event. Instead of a single generic thank-you email, send personalized follow-ups based on what you've learned:

- If someone's goal was career growth, send them resources and membership benefits tied to that goal.
- If they attended a specific session, share related content or invite them to a follow-up webinar.

Then, make the membership invitation feel like a natural next step: "You attended our leadership workshop. Becoming a member gives you ongoing access to these resources and this community."

STEP 4

Keep the conversation alive

Not everyone will join immediately. Set up a short nurture sequence to continue building trust over the next few weeks.

QUICK CHECKLIST

Use this to make your next event an acquisition engine:

- ☐ Add one strategic question to the registration form.
- ☐ Build a segmented post-event follow-up sequence.
- ☐ Craft personalized membership invitations based on attendee data.
- ☐ Track conversions to measure event ROI.

STRATEGY FOUR

Tap into your existing members with a referral program

Your best recruiters are already on your roster

THE PROBLEM

Associations often focus their acquisition efforts entirely on external marketing (social ads, events, email campaigns) while overlooking one of their most valuable assets: current members.

Your members are already bought into your mission, and they're living proof of the value your association provides. They also just so happen to be surrounded by colleagues and peers who could benefit from joining.

Without a clear referral process, their enthusiasm goes untapped. Here's what typically happens:

- A few members organically spread the word.
- Others want to help but don't know how.
- Which ends up leading to a trickle of referrals instead of a steady stream of new prospects.

THE SOLUTION

Create a structured referral program that makes it easy (and rewarding) for members to help you grow. When done right, referral campaigns are powerful because:

- Prospects trust recommendations from peers far more than marketing messages.
- They lower acquisition costs since you're tapping into existing relationships.
- They strengthen engagement with current members by making them feel like insiders.

STEP 1

Define the "why"

Make your program's purpose clear and compelling. Why should members care about bringing others in? How does it connect to your mission?

EXAMPLE MESSAGING

"Help us grow the future of this profession by inviting peers to join our community. More members mean richer resources, better programs, and greater opportunities for you to grow and succeed."

STEP 2

Offer a meaningful incentive

The incentive doesn't have to be monetary. It just needs to motivate action. Ideas include:

- Exclusive swag or recognition (e.g., special badge at your annual conference).
- Discounts on future event registrations or membership dues.
- Entry into a giveaway for a high-value prize.
- Donations to a charity on their behalf.

STEP 3

Make it easy to participate

If your referral process is complicated, members won't do it. Provide a shareable link or QR code they can send directly to prospects.

Create a member toolkit with ready-to-use assets:

Sample social media posts

Email templates

Talking points

Automate tracking so members can see their progress.

STEP 4

Follow up and say thank you

The most important — and most overlooked! — step: Always close the loop.

- Thank members for every referral, no matter how small.
- Publicly recognize top referrers in newsletters, at events, or on social media.
- Update them when their referrals actually join.

This keeps momentum going and builds a culture of advocacy.

QUICK CHECKLIST

To launch your referral program today:

- ☐ Decide on your program's purpose and incentive.
- ☐ Create a simple, shareable referral process.
- ☐ Build a toolkit for members with ready-to-share assets.
- ☐ Automate outreach and tracking where possible.
- ☐ Publicly thank and celebrate your top advocates.

STRATEGY FIVE

Create student-to-professional pipelines

Don't lose the next generation at graduation

THE PROBLEM

Associations work hard to recruit student members through discounted memberships, special programming, campus outreach. And it works. Students join. Engagement looks good.

But then comes graduation. The student discount expires. They receive one or two generic "renew now" emails. Life gets hectic — new jobs, moving cities, financial pressures. Membership quietly lapses.

Result: Years of effort invested in recruiting students vanish just as they're entering the most valuable phase of their careers.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Converting students into professional members isn't just about filling a renewal gap. It's about building lifelong loyalty. Early-career members often become highly engaged leaders, volunteers, and advocates. Associations that nail this transition secure a steady pipeline of future board members, speakers, and champions.

THE SOLUTION

Instead of treating graduation like an ending, treat it like the start of a new journey. This requires three key components: engagement early, personalized transition campaigns, and professional onboarding.

STEP 1

Engage early and often

Don't wait until graduation to start building relationships.

- Host student-only events or meetups.
- Offer mentorship programs connecting students with professionals.
- Send content focused on their immediate challenges, like landing internships or passing certification exams.

STEP 2

Identify and segment graduating students

Use your AMS or CRM to tag students approaching graduation. Look at membership expiration dates, age ranges, or graduation year data. Segment them for targeted communications.

With PropFuel, this process can be automated: Ask students directly when they expect to graduate. Their response updates their profile instantly, setting the stage for tailored outreach.

STEP 3

Create a transition campaign

As graduation nears, launch a multi-step campaign that guides students into professional membership.

TIMING	MESSAGE TYPE	EXAMPLE MESSAGE
60 days before graduation	Email check-in	"Congrats! Graduation is coming up. What's next for you? How can we stay connected post-graduation?"
30 days before	Benefits highlight	"Your professional membership unlocks resources to support your job search."
7 days before	Personalized invitation	"We'd love to continue supporting your career. Here's a special rate to help you transition."
14 days after	Follow-up reminder	"We're here when you're ready — don't miss access to our networking events."

This graduation journey should feel like a celebration, not a transaction.

STEP 4

Onboard new professionals

Once they join, immediately onboard them into their new phase of membership.

- Welcome them with a personalized message: "Congratulations on starting your career! Here are three resources our professional members love."
- Introduce them to other young professionals in the community.
- Invite them to a "new professionals" orientation or networking event.

The goal: make them feel seen and excited to be part of the organization.

QUICK CHECKLIST

Use this list to start building your student-to-professional pipeline today:

- ☐ Identify and tag all current student members.
- ☐ Collect graduation dates through a quick question or survey.
- ☐ Design a 4-step transition campaign.
- ☐ Build onboarding resources specifically for new professionals.
- ☐ Track conversion rates to measure success and refine messaging.

05

Metrics that matter: measuring acquisition success

Four numbers and a mini ROI calculator

If you can't measure it, you can't improve it

THE PROBLEM WITH MEMBERSHIP METRICS

Most associations either track too many numbers or not enough of the right ones. Some teams get stuck on vanity metrics: impressions, likes, generic open rates. Others can't answer core questions like:

"How many prospects are actually converting into members each month?"

"Which campaigns are driving the most joins?"

"What's the ROI of our recruitment budget?"

Without the right metrics, acquisition decisions become a guessing game, and that usually leads to wasted resources and stagnant growth.

The metrics that matter most

There are four key metrics every membership team should track to measure acquisition success and make data-driven decisions. These numbers reveal where to focus your efforts for maximum impact.

01 Conversion rate by stage

What it is: The percentage of prospects who move from one stage of your acquisition funnel to the next.

Why it matters: Helps you pinpoint exactly where prospects are falling off, so you can fix the leaks in your funnel.

STAGE	EXAMPLE CONVERSION QUESTION
Awareness → Interest	"How many website visitors take action, like filling out a form or answering a pop-up question?"
Interest → Consideration	"How many prospects engage with nurturing content, like opening emails or attending an event?"
Consideration → Join	"How many prospects actually become paying members?"

Goal: Identify where the biggest drop-offs happen so you can focus your resources on that stage.

02 Cost per acquired member (CPAM)

What it is: How much you spend to acquire one new member.

FORMULA

Total Recruitment Spend ÷ Number of New Members Acquired

Why it matters: If CPAM is climbing while membership growth is flat, you're spending more and getting less — a sign that your strategy or channels need adjusting.

EXAMPLE

If you spent \$5,000 on an event campaign and gained 50 new members:

\$5,000 ÷ 50 = \$100 CPAM

03 Member lifetime value (LTV)

What it is: The total financial value a member contributes to your association over the course of their relationship—including annual dues and additional non-dues revenue (events, certifications, products, etc.).

FORMULA

Average Annual Revenue per Member (dues + non-dues) × Average Years Retained

Why it matters: LTV shows you the long-term return from each new member. It's a critical benchmark for deciding how much you can afford to invest in acquisition and engagement while still growing sustainably. Increasing retention (even by one year) or boosting non-dues revenue both increase LTV.

EXAMPLE

If your average member pays \$200 in dues + \$100 in non-dues revenue each year and stays for 5 years:

$$(\$200 + \$100) \times 5 = \text{\textbf{\$1,500 LTV}}$$

If your CPAM is \$150 and your LTV is \$1,500, you're looking at a healthy 10:1 return.

04 Campaign ROI

What it is: Measures the return on investment for a specific acquisition campaign.

FORMULA

$$(\text{Revenue Generated} - \text{Campaign Costs}) \div \text{Campaign Costs} \times 100$$

Why it matters: Lets you compare campaigns side-by-side to see what's truly driving growth.

EXAMPLE

You spent \$10,000 on a referral campaign that generated \$30,000 in new member revenue:

$$(\$30,000 - \$10,000) \div \$10,000 \times 100 = \mathbf{200\% \text{ ROI}}$$

Why conversational engagement outperforms traditional email

Traditional broadcast emails typically see click-through rates below 3% in the association space.

Conversational engagement emails — where you ask a question and invite a response — see 8-12% response rates on average.

That's up to 8x higher engagement, meaning more data captured and more prospects moving down the funnel. *(Source: PropFuel Email Benchmarking Report 2024)*



Mini ROI calculator

Use this simple spreadsheet layout to track performance across campaigns:

CAMPAIGN NAME	TOTAL COST	NEW MEMBERS	CPAM	REVENUE GENERATED	ROI %
Summer Promo	\$5,000	50	\$100	\$15,000	200%

WHY THIS MATTERS

Tracking these four metrics isn't just about impressing your board with data points. It's about knowing where to focus your energy:

- If your biggest drop-off is between Interest and Consideration → improve your nurture campaigns (see Strategy #2).
- If CPAM is too high → experiment with referral programs or student pipelines (see Strategies #4 and #5).
- If ROI is unclear → test new channels, like SMS or website personalization, and measure their impact.

When you track the right numbers, you stop guessing — and start growing strategically.

06

The 30-day acquisition quick start plan

Four weekly sprints

Turn ideas into action in just one month

WHY A 30-DAY PLAN MATTERS

It's easy to read a playbook like this and think, "Great ideas, but where do I start?"

The truth is, you don't need to overhaul everything at once. Big, lasting membership growth comes from small, intentional steps taken consistently. This quick-start plan helps you:

- Get momentum fast.
- Show early wins to your team or board.
- Lay the foundation for long-term success.

How it works

Over the next 30 days, you'll focus on four weekly sprints, each building on the last:

WEEK	FOCUS AREA	GOAL
Week 1	Audit & Align	Identify what's working and what's broken
Week 2	Website Conversion	Capture more leads from visitors
Week 3	Nurture Journey	Build trust and guide prospects toward joining
Week 4	Measurement & Scaling	Track success and plan next steps



WEEK 1

Audit & align

Goal: Understand your current acquisition funnel and align your team around priorities.

STEPS

MAP YOUR FUNNEL

- Awareness → Interest → Consideration → Join → Retain
- Identify where prospects are dropping off.
- Use your AMS, CRM, or even a whiteboard to visualize the journey.

COLLECT BASELINE METRICS

- Current conversion rates, CPAM, and renewal rates.
- These will be your "before" numbers to show progress later.

CHOOSE ONE ACQUISITION STRATEGY TO FOCUS ON FIRST

- Don't try to do it all at once. Pick the area with the biggest opportunity (website, nurture, events, etc.).

PRO TIP

If you're unsure where to start, focus on website optimization first.
It's usually the fastest way to see a measurable impact.

WEEK 2

Optimize your website for conversion

Goal: Turn anonymous visitors into known prospects you can nurture.

ADD A CONVERSATIONAL POP-UP TO YOUR HOMEPAGE

- Include a question on your website that starts leading prospects to relevant pages while also helping you learn more about why people are visiting your site. Start with something like "what brings you to the website today?"

SIMPLIFY YOUR JOIN NOW PAGE

- Remove friction like unnecessary fields or jargon.

CREATE CLEAR, VISIBLE CALLS-TO-ACTION FOR PROSPECTS

- "Join Today", "Explore Benefits", "Get Involved".

DELIVERABLE BY END OF WEEK

A live pop-up or form capturing prospect intent, plus a simplified join process.

WEEK 3

Build a simple nurture journey

Goal: Guide prospects from interest to membership with relevant, timely touchpoints.

DRAFT FOUR CORE MESSAGES

- **Welcome:** Thank them for engaging + ask about their goals.
- **Value:** Share a resource tailored to their interests.
- **Story:** Showcase a member success story that matches their goals.
- **Join:** Extend a clear, compelling invitation.

DECIDE ON TIMING

- Spread messages over 10–14 days.
- Use email first; layer in SMS or direct mail later.

SEGMENT YOUR AUDIENCE BASED ON THE POP-UP RESPONSES FROM WEEK 2

DAY	MESSAGE TYPE
Day 1	Welcome + Question
Day 3	Resource related to their interest
Day 7	Success Story
Day 14	Join Invitation

DELIVERABLE BY END OF WEEK

A fully mapped nurture flow with at least 4 touchpoints ready to deploy.

WEEK 4

Measure, learn, and scale

Goal: Track results, prove impact, and identify next steps for scaling.

REVISIT THE METRICS FROM SECTION 5

Conversion rates

CPAM

Campaign ROI

CREATE A SIMPLE REPORT TO SHARE WITH YOUR TEAM OR BOARD

DECIDE ON YOUR NEXT GROWTH LEVER

- Add SMS or website personalization.
- Launch a referral program.
- Build a student-to-professional pipeline.

PRO TIP

Even small early wins can secure buy-in for bigger projects down the road.

Keep the momentum going

By the end of 30 days, you'll have:

- A functioning acquisition funnel that captures and nurtures prospects.
- Baseline data to measure improvement.
- A clear understanding of what to tackle next.

This isn't just a short-term fix — it's the first step toward building a sustainable, scalable acquisition engine.



30-day snapshot

WEEK	KEY ACTION	SUCCESS METRIC
Week 1	Map Funnel & Establish Baselines — Identify every touchpoint from awareness through joining, capture current conversion rates, CPAM, and LTV.	• Documented funnel stages and KPIs for each stage • Baseline conversion rate from Awareness → Join • Buy-in from cross-functional team (membership, marketing, IT)
Week 2	Optimize First Touchpoint — Add a targeted pop-up or web engagement element, and simplify the join process (reduce clicks/forms).	• +10–15% increase in captured leads vs. baseline • Drop-off rate between Interest → Consideration decreases by 5%+
Week 3	Launch Nurture Journey — Send personalized, behavior-triggered emails or SMS campaigns based on captured data.	• 8–12% click-through rate on nurture emails • At least 5% of nurtured leads progress to Consideration
Week 4	Measure & Report Results — Analyze what worked, identify leaks in the funnel, and plan next steps.	• Acquisition dashboard built and shared with team • Key insight identified for each funnel stage • Clear next-step experiments prioritized for next 30 days

PRO TIP

With PropFuel, you can automate and scale this process. From the pop-up questions to the nurture journey to real-time reporting, you can engage prospects faster and with less manual work.

07

Conclusion and next steps

Where to go from here

The future of membership growth is conversational

BRINGING IT ALL TOGETHER

Growing your membership is meeting prospects where they are. It's about listening to their needs, showing them you understand, and guiding them to join in a way that feels natural and valuable.

Throughout this playbook, we've explored:

- The challenges associations face in today's noisy, competitive landscape.
- The Ask → Capture → Act framework for building meaningful acquisition journeys.
- Five proven strategies you can implement:
 - Optimizing your website for conversion.
 - Building a nurture journey to turn cold leads into members.
 - Leveraging events as acquisition engines.
 - Tapping into existing members with referral programs.
 - Creating pipelines to convert students into lifelong members.
- The metrics that matter, so you can track success and prove ROI.
- A 30-day quick start plan to move from ideas to action.

Why conversations drive conversions

Today's prospects are tired of one-way marketing blasts. They want to feel heard, and being heard starts with asking a question. When you ask questions, capture insights, and act on what you learn, you create a powerful cycle of trust:

Conversations → Connection → Conversions

It's not just better marketing. It's a better experience for your prospects and your team.

Your roadmap is here. Let's build it together

You now have the framework, strategies, and tools to grow your membership base in a way that's sustainable and scalable.

If you're ready to:

- Turn anonymous website visitors into known prospects,
- Build nurture journeys that convert,
- And capture the metrics your board cares about —

PropFuel can help you get there faster.

Ready to see how?

See how PropFuel can help you implement the Ask. Capture. Act. framework and start growing your membership today.

[Get a demo →](#)